

Diplomacy and decibels

From press boxes to packed stands, our reporters file diary bytes from the ground, **catching the moments** that slip past the match report.

Political twist

An ICC Twenty20 World Cup arrived against the backdrop of politics. The talk leading up to the 10th edition was all about Bangladesh seeking a neutral venue before being overruled, and Pakistan's threat of not playing against India. It was natural that Indian skipper Suryakumar Yadav spent more time on international diplomacy in press conferences than on cricket, as queries also centred around the former.

Off-field noise: At Wankhede, amid last-minute paintwork and louder questions, Suryakumar Yadav walked into a tournament where the press conference felt as tense as the PowerPlay. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Mumbai buzz

In the lead-up to India's game against the United States of America (USA), Mumbai's Wankhede Stadium was abuzz. Last-minute preparations were on, paint was being applied to promotional material, the fine-tuning of the inaugural function was also under way, and in the press box, sportswriters were getting into their groove. Wi-Fi passwords were sought, laptops hummed, and previews were being written.

Game day

On February 7, Wankhede Stadium began to swell with crowds. Even if it was not fully sold out, there were enough fans to create the high decibel levels that define top-level cricket in India. And once the glitzy inaugural ceremony finished, the focus soon shifted to cricket.

Rohit Sharma, the tournament ambassador, looked lean and dapper. His erstwhile team-mates made a beeline for him, and even Suryakumar delayed the toss by a few seconds as he ran to hug his former captain.

Even the USA unit, an amalgam of players of Indian, Pakistani, Sri Lankan and Dutch origin, was a picture of bonhomie. Once the game started, sport's ability to surprise was back in vogue. India slipped in the first phase as wickets tumbled on a pitch that was not exactly a belter.

The 360-degree charm

Suryakumar played a captain's knock high on responsibility and chutzpah. His unbeaten 84 was a

